

Porting Autoware Nodes to nano-ros

a Safety Island Case Study

Real Autoware 1.5.0 C++ nodes, near-verbatim, running the MRM chain on an RTOS — co-working with an unmodified Autoware stack.

`github.com/NEWSLabNTU/simple-autoware-safety-island` • nano-ros: `github.com/NEWSLabNTU/nano-ros`

Why a safety island?

When the main compute fails, something small and independent must stop the vehicle.

- Autoware's MRM (Minimum Risk Maneuver) chain normally runs **inside** the same Linux/DDS stack it is supposed to survive.
- Move exactly that chain to a small RTOS image — a **safety island** — and keep the rest of Autoware untouched.
- Two ROS 2 domains, one bridge, one contract:



Failure model: kill the availability heartbeat → the **island** — not Autoware — brings the vehicle to a controlled stop.

What was ported

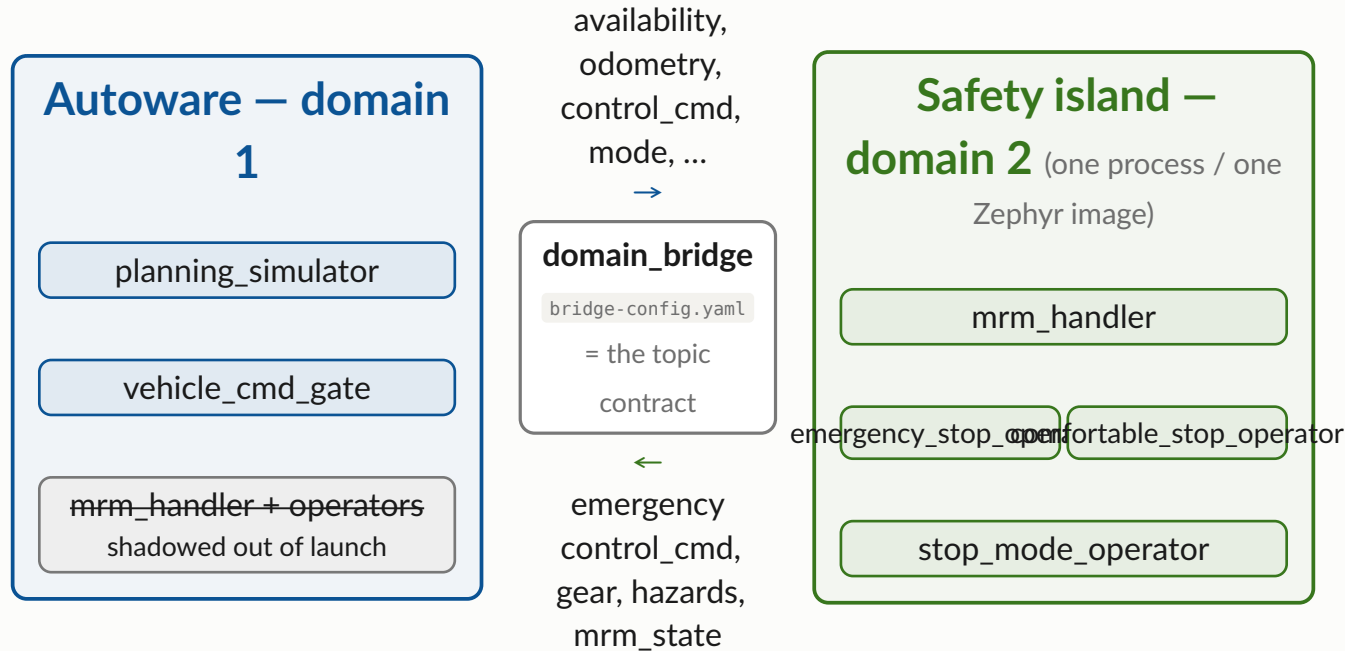
Autoware 1.5.0 • verbatim-first

From `autoware_universe/{system,control}`, easiest → hardest:

Package	LOC	Role
<code>autoware_mrm_emergency_stop_operator</code>	~156	jerk-limited hard stop ramp
<code>autoware_mrm_comfortable_stop_operator</code>	~131	gentle stop via velocity limit
<code>autoware_stop_mode_operator</code>	~110	continuous safe-command emitter
<code>autoware_mrm_handler</code>	~600	MRM state machine — the island brain

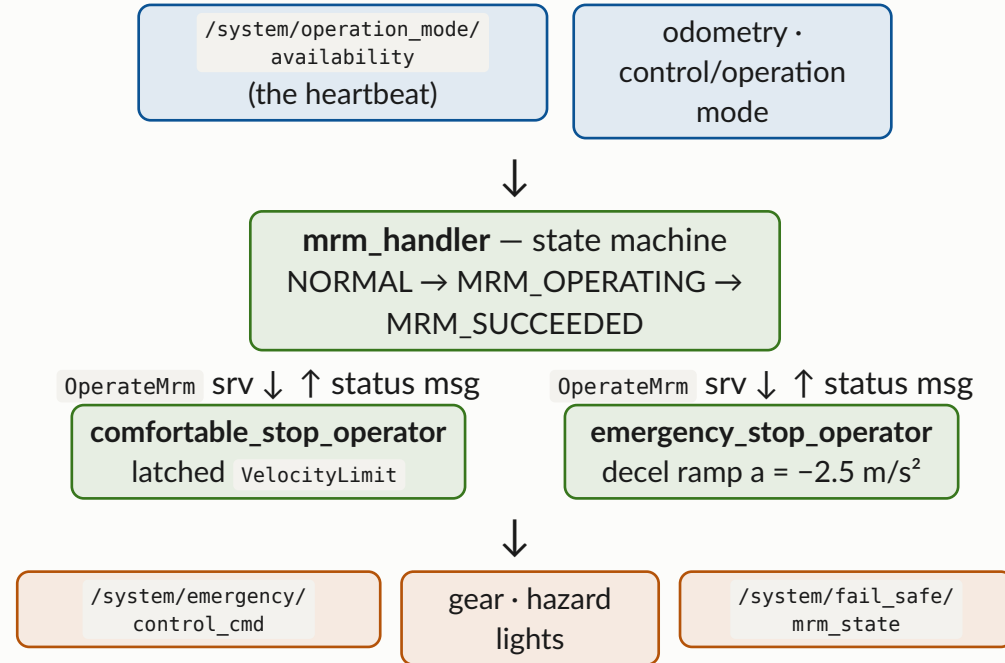
- Ported sources keep the upstream **file layout**, `package.xml`, **launch XML**, and an ament-shaped CMake surface — a ROS user recognizes everything.
- Message deps vendored **verbatim**: `autoware_control_msgs`, `autoware_vehicle_msgs`, `autoware_adapi_v1_msgs`, `tier4_system_msgs`, ... — stock `rosidl_generate_interfaces()` + `package.xml`, unchanged.

Architecture — two domains, one bridge



Nothing else crosses: `docs/topic-contract.md` is the SSoT, the bridge YAML is the machine artifact. Same island binary runs native (dev loop) and Zephyr.

Inside the island — the MRM chain



Operators tick at 30 Hz (upstream `update_rate`). Handler escalates: comfortable stop → cancel → emergency stop, exactly as in stock Autoware.

Project structure — a 3-role nano-ros workspace

CMakeLists.txt	workspace root
src/	
autoware_control_msgs/	└ vendored rosidl pkgs
autoware_vehicle_msgs/	(subset of files,
tier4_system_msgs/ ...	└ otherwise VERBATIM)
autoware_mrm_handler/	└ ported node pkgs
autoware_mrm*_operator/	(upstream layout:
autoware_stop_mode_op.../	└ include src launch config)
island_interfaces/	msg-closure shim (1 FFI union)
safety_island_bringup/	system.toml + launch XML
	+ params + resolved model
native_entry/	native entry (fast dev loop)
zephyr_entry/	Zephyr image entry
demo/	sim + domain_bridge + scenario
docs/porting-notes.md	the friction log (deliverable!)

Three roles:

interface pkgs

verbatim rosidl

node pkgs

your C++, barely touched

bringup + entry

the only nano-ros-specific part

The porting recipe

1 — vendor the message subset

Copy the `.msg / .srv` files + `package.xml` + `rosidl_generate_interfaces()` CMake — **unchanged**. nano-ros codegen consumes stock rosidl pkgs.

2 — copy the package

Keep `include/autoware/<pkg>/`, `src/`, `launch/`, `config/*.param.yaml` as-is.

3 — apply six mechanical edits →

4 — wire it up

Add the pkg to workspace CMake + one `[[component]]` block in `system.toml`; `just setup` && `just build` && `just run`.

Everything else — the actual node logic — is a diff you can read in one sitting.

The six edits (per node):

1. Base class: `rclcpp::Node` → `nros::ComponentNode` (rclcpp shape)
2. Ctor: `(const NodeOptions&)` → `(nros::NodeHandle)`
3. Callbacks: `Msg::ConstSharedPtr` → `const Msg&`
4. Register: `RCLCPP_COMPONENTS_REGISTER_NODE` → `NROS_COMPONENT(...)`
5. Topic names: write the **resolved** contract names (remaps not routed yet)
6. Value-init messages: `Response r{};` (generated structs are PODs)

Before / after — emergency stop ctor

156 LOC pkg, diff ≈ 20 lines

upstream (rclcpp)

```
MrmEmergencyStopOperator::MrmEmergencyStopOperator(
    const rclcpp::NodeOptions & node_options)
: Node("mrm_emergency_stop_operator", node_options)
{
    params_.update_rate =
        declare_parameter<int>("update_rate");
    sub_control_cmd_ = create_subscription<Control>(
        "~/input/control/control_cmd", 1,
        std::bind(&Op::onControlCommand, this, _1));
    service_operation_ = create_service<OperateMrm>(
        "~/input/mrm/emergency_stop/operate",
        std::bind(&Op::operateEmergencyStop, this, _1, _2));
    pub_status_ = create_publisher<MrmBehaviorStatus>(
        "~/output/mrm/emergency_stop/status", 1);
    timer_ = rclcpp::create_timer(this, get_clock(),
        rclcpp::Rate(params_.update_rate).period(),
        std::bind(&Op::onTimer, this));
}
RCLCPP_COMPONENTS_REGISTER_NODE(
    autoware::mrm_emergency_stop_operator::
    MrmEmergencyStopOperator)
```

ported (nano-ros)

```
MrmEmergencyStopOperator::MrmEmergencyStopOperator(
    ::nros::NodeHandle handle)
: ::nros::ComponentNode(handle,
    "mrm_emergency_stop_operator")
{
    params_.update_rate =
        declare_parameter<int64_t>("update_rate", 30);
    NROS_SUBSCRIBE(Control, onControlCommand,
        "/control/command/control_cmd");
    ::nros::bind_service<OperateMrm, Op,
        &Op::operateEmergencyStop>(
        node(), "/system/mrm/emergency_stop/operate", this);
    pub_status_ = create_publisher<MrmBehaviorStatus>(
        "/system/mrm/emergency_stop/status");
    NROS_CREATE_TIMER(
        1000 / params_.update_rate, onTimer);
}
NROS_COMPONENT(
    autoware_mrm_emergency_stop_operator::
    MrmEmergencyStopOperator);
```

Timer/pub/sub bodies, the ramp math, the state handling — **byte-identical** to upstream.

CMake and launch — ament-shaped on purpose

Node pkg CMake — `ament_cmake_auto` becomes one verb:

```
find_package(nano_ros REQUIRED)
find_package(tier4_system_msgs REQUIRED)

nano_ros_add_node(mrm_emergency_stop_operator
  CLASS autoware_mrm_emergency_stop_operator::
    MrmEmergencyStopOperator
  HEADER autoware/mrm_emergency_stop_operator/
    mrm_emergency_stop_operator_core.hpp
  SHAPE rclcpp
  SOURCES src/.../mrm_emergency_stop_operator_core.cpp)
```

No `main()` — the node pkg builds a component; the **entry** pkg owns boot.

Bringup — launch XML stays ROS 2 schema, verbatim:

```
<launch>
  <node pkg="autoware_mrm_handler"
    exec="mrm_handler" name="mrm_handler"/>
  <node pkg="autoware_mrm_emergency_stop_operator"
    exec="mrm_emergency_stop_operator" .../>
  ...
</launch>
```

`system.toml` adds what ROS has no word for — domain, RMW, components, tiers:

```
play_launch resolve safety_island.launch.xml
--system system.toml -o system_model.yaml
```

One resolved model bakes into **both** the native and the Zephyr entry.

What to expect — API surface

porting-notes 01-05, 13

#	Upstream expects	What you do	Status
01	<code>create_service</code> , <code>params</code> , <code>now()</code> on <code>rclcpp::Node</code> — compat header covers pub/sub/timer/QoS/ log only	derive <code>nros::ComponentNode</code> (rclcpp shape); services via <code>nros::bind_service</code>	open
04	<code>Msg::ConstSharedPtr</code> callbacks	<code>const Msg&</code> — no <code>shared_ptr</code> message ownership	by design
05	<code>rclcpp::Clock</code> / <code>Time</code> arithmetic	<code>nros_cpp_time_ns()</code> + dt from message stamps (monotonic epoch)	open
13	C++17 (<code>std::optional</code>)	C++14 surface — sentinel flag + value; mechanical	by design

All of these are **local, mechanical** edits — the compiler finds every site for you.

What to expect — semantics

porting-notes 06, 07, 09, 14

#	Upstream expects	What you do	Status
07	<code>~/private</code> names + launch <code><remap></code> routing	write resolved contract names in-source; launch XML keeps remaps as documentation	open
06	params injected from <code>*.param.yaml</code> at launch	param-file values become in-code <code>declare_parameter</code> defaults (node-local)	open
09	rosidl C++ zero-initializes messages	value-init: <code>Response r{};</code> — generated structs are PODs (garbage leaked on the wire otherwise)	open — fix planned
14	<code>polling_subscriber</code> , blocking service futures	cache-latest member subs; send-and-poll service clients (no nested spin in a timer cb)	open

#09 is the one that **bites silently** — make `{}` a porting reflex.

What to expect — build & scale

5 nano-ros fixes landed same-day

#	Friction → outcome	Status
08	two interface pkgs on one link line → duplicate FFI symbols → nano-ros now builds one topo-last superset crate; also: msg constants as struct members (MrmBehaviorStatus::AVAILABLE)	fixed in nano-ros
10	rclcpp::QoS(5) / .transient_local() spelling → depth ctor added; ported code unchanged	fixed in nano-ros
16	type-descriptor registry cap 64, overflow silent (island registers ~86 types) → cap 256 + override knob	fixed in nano-ros
18	Zephyr minimal libcpp: stub <new> broke every component factory → placement-new forms declared	fixed in nano-ros
11	executor callback slots = compile-time env knob (NROS_EXECUTOR_MAX_CBS); boot fails loud (Full) → export 16+; codegen-derived sizing filed	open
12/15	one msg-closure per workspace (island_interfaces shim); full-pkg deps drag srv IDL embedded idlc rejects → vendor msg-only subsets	open

The protocol: every friction point → `porting-notes.md` entry → nano-ros issue → fix **upstream**, not a local fork.

Zephyr: one image, four nodes

Entry pkg = prj.conf + one CMake verb:

```
CONFIG_NROS=y
CONFIG_NROS_CPP_API=y
CONFIG_STD_CPP14=y
CONFIG_NETWORKING=y CONFIG_NET_UDP=y ...
# sized up for 30+ DDS entities:
CONFIG_MAX_PTHREAD_MUTEX_COUNT=1024
nano_ros_add_executable(zephyr_entry
  BOARD zephyr TYPED DEPLOY zephyr
  MODEL .../config/system_model.yaml)
```

Same model as native — no `[deploy]` pins, so nodes stay board-agnostic.

Build & run:

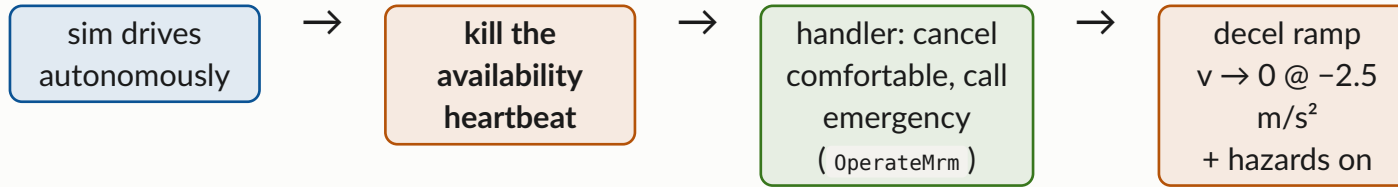
```
just zephyr-build # west build -b native_sim/native/64
just zephyr-run   # ./build-zephyr/zephyr/zephyr.exe
```

Talking to it from the host: `native_sim` bakes multicast-off, unicast-peer discovery — the host must mirror it:

```
just host-env # prints CYCLONEDDS_URI:
# lo iface, AllowMulticast=false,
# Peer 127.0.0.1, ParticipantIndex auto
```

With that: the full e2e passes against `zephyr.exe` — identical result to native.

The demo — heartbeat loss, island stops the car



- Verified end-to-end on **native** (P3) and on the **Zephyr image** (P4) — same scenario, same transitions, `/system/fail_safe/mrm_state` → `MRM_OPERATING`.
- Co-sim (P5): host Autoware 1.5.0 `planning_simulator` + `domain_bridge`; stock MRM nodes shadowed out of the launch — the island is the **only** MRM path.

```
just demo-sim          # planning_simulator, domain 1
just demo-bridge       # domain_bridge with the contract yaml
just run               # the island, domain 2
just demo-kill-heartbeat
```

Scorecard

Worked well

- Vended rosidl pkgs build **verbatim** — they even double as the host colcon overlay
- Node logic ports near-verbatim; ~600-LOC state machine unchanged
- Launch XML consumed as-is; ament-shaped CMake
- QoS chains (`transient_local` latched pubs) just work
- Same sources, native ↔ Zephyr, identical e2e behavior
- Friction→issue→same-day-fix loop with nano-ros mainline

Gaps (rclcpp-compat trajectory)

services / params / clock in the compat header	next
<code><remap></code> routing + <code>~/</code> expansion	planned
param-file projection at launch	planned
zero-initialized generated messages	planned
service clients with futures, callback groups	open
executor sizing derived from the model	filed

Every gap has a documented, mechanical workaround — see `docs/porting-notes.md` (19 entries).

Takeaways — you can port your own nodes

1. **The port is mostly a copy.** Msg pkgs verbatim; node pkgs keep their layout; six mechanical edits per node, and the compiler finds every site.
2. **Your ROS 2 knowledge transfers.** `package.xml`, launch XML, QoS spellings, the ament CMake shape — all recognizable; `system.toml` is the only new file.
3. **The friction is finite and logged.** 19 notes from four packages; 5 fixes already in nano-ros mainline — the list **shrinks** as compat grows.
4. **The payoff is real:** the actual Autoware MRM chain on an RTOS image, stopping the vehicle when the main stack dies.

Start here: `github.com/NEWSLabNTU/simple-autoware-safety-island` — README quick start, `docs/porting-notes.md`,
`docs/topic-contract.md`

nano-ros: `github.com/NEWSLabNTU/nano-ros` — RFC-0044 (rclcpp shape), RFC-0028 (safety / E2E), the `nros` CLI + `play_launch`